

Questions for Debbie

Understanding the Real Landscape

The Team & Culture

- How large is the team today, and what's the mix of skillsets (MES specialists, labeling, plant digitalization)?
- Who are the strongest performers, and who might need development or support?
- How does the team dynamic work across the Libertyville and Stuarts Draft sites — is there tension or good collaboration?
- What's the team's morale like right now, especially with the leadership transition?

The Tech Stack — Reality vs. JD

- The JD mentions Critical Manufacturing as the MES platform — how mature is that implementation? Is it fully deployed or mid-rollout?
- What's the actual state of the SAP integration (ECC vs. S4/HANA migration)?
- Where are the biggest technical debt issues or systems being held together with duct tape?
- Which labeling platform are they using, and what are its pain points?
- How real is the IIoT/smart factory/AI vision versus aspirational?

Regulatory & Compliance

- What keeps you up at night regarding FDA/GMP/ISO:13485 compliance on the systems side?
- How mature are the validation practices — is there a solid CSV framework, or is it being built?
- When was the last audit, and what findings (if any) touched your domain?
- What's the state of disaster recovery — has it actually been tested, or is it largely on paper?

Political & Organizational Intelligence

- Who are the key stakeholders I need to build relationships with first — in manufacturing, quality, and IT leadership?
- Where does this role sit in the org chart, and who do you report to? What's that relationship like?
- What's the relationship between IT and the manufacturing/plant floor teams — collaborative or adversarial?
- Are there any politically sensitive projects or vendor relationships I should be aware of?
- What's the budget reality — is there genuine investment appetite, or is it "do more with less"?

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Strategic & Practical

- What's the single biggest opportunity you wish you'd had time to pursue?
- What's the biggest risk or problem that needs immediate attention in the first 90 days?
- If you could give your successor one piece of advice, what would it be?
- Why are they open to contract, contract-to-hire, *and* direct hire — is there uncertainty about the role's future or funding?
- What does "hybrid" actually look like — how many days on-site, and is there pressure to be at the plants frequently?

Your Unique Positioning Questions

Given your semantic governance and knowledge engineering background, you might also probe:

- How is manufacturing data currently governed — is there a metadata strategy, or is it siloed by system?
- Are they thinking about digital twins or connected data models across the manufacturing lifecycle?
- How do they manage the knowledge/documentation around their validated systems — is it structured or tribal?

These last questions do double duty: they give you intel *and* subtly demonstrate the strategic depth you'd bring beyond what the JD describes.